



Figure 1: Vim with PHPCS

because of a number of reasons like laziness to follow and review code, inadequate knowledge or the pressure to deliver. Whatever the reason, the impact becomes higher as the project progresses.

In order to follow coding standards and make it a part of a programmer's habit, one should use coding standard sniffers.

A sniffer is a tool or script that detects the flaws in the code, as per the coding standards, and provides detailed reports to the user. So every developer can check the coding standard before the code is committed. There is no need for another person to review the code. It becomes the individual developer's responsibility to create standards-based code. After some code commits, this will become a habit and the developer will start writing code based on proper standards.

To check PHP coding standards, you can use the PHP CodeSniffer (PHPCS). The prerequisites to using PHPCS are:

- PHP CLI version 5.1.2 or greater
- PEAR packages, PEAR Installer 1.4.0b1 or newer

Installation

PHP CodeSniffer is provided as one of the PEAR packages and is developed by using PHP. At present, the latest stable version is 1.5.2.

To install it in Debian or Ubuntu Linux, use the following commands:

```
#apt-get install php-codesniffer
```

This will automatically install PEAR and all the required packages.

To install with the PEAR package manager, use the following commands:

```
#pear install PHP_CodeSniffer-1.5.2
```

To do manual installation, directly download the latest package and use it. Download the link: http://download.pear.php.net/package/PHP_CodeSniffer-1.5.2.tgz

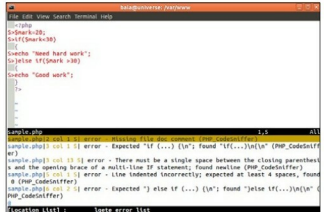


Figure 2: PHPCS error report on Vim

Sample usage

Let's take a look at how the code sniffer can be used on a sample PHP file. Just follow the few simple steps listed below:

1. Download the package and unpack it.
2. Create the sample PHP file to check the coding standard, called sample1.php:

```

<?php
$mark=20;
if($mark>30)
{
    echo "Need hard work;";
}
else if($mark >30)
{
    echo "Good work;";
}
}
>

```

3. Use the following command to check the coding standard:

```
$ cd PHP_CodeSniffer-1.5.2/scripts/
$. /phpcs /var/www/sample1.php
```

```
FILE: /var/www/sample1.php
```

```
FOUND 8 ERROR(S) AFFECTING 5 LINE(S)
```

```

2 | ERROR | Missing file doc comment
3 | ERROR | Expected "if (...) {\n"; found "if(...)\\n{\\n"
3 | ERROR | There must be a single space between the closing
parenthesis and
| | the opening brace of a multi-line IF statement;
found newline
5 | ERROR | Line indented incorrectly; expected at least 4
spaces, found 0
6 | ERROR | Expected "else if (...) {\n"; found "else
if(...)\\n{\\n"
6 | ERROR | Expected "if (...) {\n"; found "if(...)\\n{\\n"

```